



Kenneth John Penrith Asher

1897 - 1916

Civilian Research

		Source of data
Casualty Name	Asher, K (on the war memorial) Asher, Kenneth John Penrith Also referred to as Asher, K J P	https://www.greatwarforum.org/topic/240025-cs-ds-charity-challenge-officers-died-1716-photos-needed/
Date of Birth	4 Feb 1897	See NOTES below
Date of Death (from Spreadsheet)	01 July 1916 OR 2 July 1916	The digitised lists of soldier's effects on Ancestry has written 2/7/1914. I've saved it but not pasted on this sheet. But the Medal Roll (also on Ancestry) states 1/7/1916
Age at death (from Spreadsheet)	Not on spreadsheet but Harrow Observer says "in his 20 th year" ie 19. See newspaper cutting below. And based on date of birth.	Harrow Observer (from FMP)
Marital Status	Based on death reports I'd say unmarried	
Children (if any)	None	

Occupation prior to Call up	Student possibly since he is listed in U of London Military Record	
Parents	Mr & Mrs Penrith Asher (only son) Research on Ancestry gives parents' names as: George Willis Penrith Asher and Esther Florence Asher (nee Fallon). His parents were married in Algiers	Harrow Observer (FMP) 14/7/1916 see clip below. NB inconsistency in date. The Daily Telegraph & Courier (London) has the same entry on the 12/7/1916 Evidence of marriage of parents and MMN downloaded from Ancestry
Listed Address(s)	56 Hindes Road, Harrow 17 College Road, Harrow	1916 at the time he died 1911 census
Parents /Fathers occupation	In the 1921 census he is a bank manager working for Credito Italiano so possibly something similar previously. Also note on trip to Argentina he is listed as an Agent.	Ancestry
Brothers and Sisters	2 sisters: Geraldine Esther and Cecile Helene Denise	According to someone's family tree on Ancestry
Years at John Lyon School	1906 – 1913	Harrow Observer Obit #2
University (if any)	University of London likely	According to someone's family tree on Ancestry – student military record – see below
Obituary	See Harrow Observer 14/7/1916 and Daily Telegraph & Courier 12/7/1916 as mentioned above. Also he is commemorated in St John the Baptist Church, Station Road, Greenhill, Harrow, London HA1 2EB Also he is commemorated in St Peters Church, Summer Road, Harrow, London HA1 4BX Also the Harrow on the Hill War Memorial	Church memorial: https://memorials.iwm.org.uk/name/340726 Includes image of memorial https://memorials.iwm.org.uk/memorial/11139 https://memorials.iwm.org.uk/name/249794 https://memorials.iwm.org.uk/memorial/11170 https://memorials.iwm.org.uk/name/340000

	And the 2 memorials at JLS	
Additional sources of data		
Great War Forum article confirms his Christian names	Kenneth John Penrith	https://www.greatwarforum.org/topic/240025-cs-ds-charity-challenge-officers-died-1716-photos-needed/
Confirmation of him as a casualty at this website	See Notes below	https://ossett.net/WW1/Squire_Cooper.html
Image of his CWGC headstone at this website		http://www.webmatters.net/index.php?id=295
Student military record from University of London. No new info just his name, regiment and that he died on 1/7/1914		Ancestry. I've saved the record but not pasted it here.

Military Research

JLS WWI RoH	ASHER K.J.P.
CWGC Reference	https://www.cwgc.org/find-war-dead/casualty/39370/asher,-/
Age	
DoD	01-Jul-16
Rank	2 Lt
Regiment	King's Own Yorkshire Light Infantry 10th Bn
	<u>NORFOLK CEMETERY, BECORDEL-BECOURT</u>
Location	Somme, France
Military details	2Lt Asher served in the trenches of the Western Front and was killed in action on July 1, 1916, during the infamous First Day of the Somme. His battalion launched an assault at 07:30 AM from the British front lines near Fricourt. He was one of ten officers from his battalion killed that morning. He is buried at the Norfolk Cemetery, Bécordel-Bécourt in France

Story of Sacrifice

Kenneth John Penrith Asher (1897–1916)

Kenneth John Penrith Asher was a pupil and later Captain of the Lower School of John Lyon before joining the Army during the First World War. His surviving letters home provide a detailed account of his training and life on the Western Front, ending with his death on the opening day of the Somme offensive in July 1916.

Civilian Life

Kenneth John Penrith Asher was born in Algiers on 4 February 1897, the son of George Willis Penrith Asher and Esther Florence Asher. He was the only son and had two younger sisters, Geraldine and Cecile. The family later lived in Harrow, at 17 College Road and subsequently at 56 Hindes Road.

Kenneth entered the Lower School of John Lyon in 1906 and remained there until 1913. During his school years he became a member of the local Cadet Corps and was Captain of the School when he left. The school records describe him as an Old Lyonian, and he was later commemorated on the school's First World War memorials.

Military Life

Kenneth enlisted in the 9th Battalion, Middlesex Regiment, in August 1914. He received his commission in December 1914 and subsequently served as a Second Lieutenant. By March 1916 he had gone to France with the 10th Battalion, King's Own Yorkshire Light Infantry (KOYLI), part of the British Expeditionary Force and 21st Division.

His letters from France describe the routine and conditions of service. On 3 April 1916, he wrote that he was censoring around 50 letters a day. He described seeing British, French and German aircraft overhead and watching artillery fire at an aircraft, which he said looked "jolly pretty" against the blue sky.

In another letter, dated 26 April, Kenneth described the constant movement of the battalion: "We seem to do nothing but push round France laden like mules." He also described attending a gas demonstration, where he had to walk through chlorine gas wearing a respirator, and encountering lachrymatory gas, which he said had a fruity smell and made his eyes water.

His letters also record the dangers of life near the front. He told Cecile that he had narrowly escaped being hit by a bullet while working behind the trenches. On another occasion, while returning in darkness, he nearly fell into what turned out to be a well.

Writing to *The Lyonian*, the John Lyon School magazine, on 24 May 1916, Kenneth gave a detailed account of life as a subaltern. He described being sent out with working parties of men carrying picks and shovels, sometimes to repair trenches damaged by artillery fire. He wrote that trench life could be "very dull" but that when it was not dull, "it is too exciting to be pleasant."

He also described a heavy German bombardment which he said was the hottest the battalion had experienced. During the hour-long bombardment, a shell landed on the roof of the dug-out where he was sheltering, leaving him partly buried in chalk. Several other shells burst nearby, and he described feeling the blast and smelling the powder. After the bombardment ended, he went around the trenches collecting shell fragments as souvenirs.

Death on the Somme

Kenneth Asher was serving with the 10th Battalion, King's Own Yorkshire Light Infantry, when the battalion took part in the opening assault of the Battle of the Somme on 1 July 1916.

The battalion war diary records that the 10th KOYLI led the 64th Brigade assault, leaving the trenches at 7.30 a.m. and taking Crucifix Trench that morning. Among the officers recorded as killed was "2nd Lt. K.J.P. Asher." The battalion suffered heavy casualties that day, including ten officers killed, 50 other ranks killed, 292 wounded and 135 missing.

The Commonwealth War Graves Commission record gives Kenneth's date of death as 1 July 1916. Contemporary newspaper reports recorded his death as 2 July, and the research document notes this discrepancy. He was 19 years old. He was buried at Norfolk Cemetery, Bécordel-Bécourt, in France.

Kenneth John Penrith Asher died during the opening day of the Somme offensive, aged 19, while serving as a Second Lieutenant with the 10th King's Own Yorkshire Light Infantry. His letters, preserved by his family and published in the John Lyon School magazine, provide a contemporary record of his experiences of military life in France in the months before his death.

Photos



Kenneth Asher sepia



Kenneth Asher edited to BW



Kenneth Asher 1914 original



Kenneth Asher signed studio photo



Kenneth Asher Field Grave



Kenneth Asher with sister 1st Day of School



Kenneth Asher original

Notes and Clippings

Research Notes:

Looking at someone else's family tree on Ancestry. It confirmed (as long as it's correct) that he was born in Algeria. Villa Baia, Mustapha, Algeria (Algiers) and date. It also confirmed his parents' full names. Although he was the only son, he had two sisters.

Photograph of him on the online family tree. We asked permission and contacted the person who owns the family tree on Ancestry Here is their reply:

2nd July 2026:

Dear Tim,

I was delighted to receive the message on Ancestry with regard to Kenneth Asher, who fell on the first day of the Battle of the Somme. My father, Kenneth's nephew, now 93, was named after him. Kenneth was so deeply mourned by his family that we have a wealth of carefully saved information: copies of the school magazines which published his letters home and another with the announcement of his death (I expect you have these in the school archives); the devastating telegram sent home to his family; letters from the front and many photographs, all kept in the metal box which was sent home from the trenches.

I absolutely know that he and his parents would be thrilled that these documents could be made available for others to see as part of the Old Lyonian Association.

Do let me know how I can help and what you would like to see. As a start, I roughly transcribed his letters home from the front a few years ago, so I attach them for you here with a few photos (Gerry and Cess were his two younger sisters).

With very best wishes

Helen

Other Notes

In 1911 Census the family minus their father George are living at 17 College Road, Harrow. The mother, mother-in-law a widow, 3 children and a servant. Ancestry/FMP. Have downloaded it.

Date of death: newspaper reports say 2/7/1916 while some other sources like CWGC say 1/7/1916. The soldiers effects document (original) states 2/7/1916 – so this is something that needs sorting out.

Extract from Regimental Diary. Confirmation as casualty. "The 10th KOYLI were involved in the attack on Fricourt on the opening day of the Battle of the Somme on the 1st July 1916 as part of 64 Brigade, 21st Division. The 64th (Northern Brigade) in 21 Division consisted of the 9th and 10th Kings Own Yorkshire Light Infantry (KOYLI) in the front line, with the 15th Battalion Durham Light Infantry (DLI) and the 1st Battalion East Yorkshire Regiment in reserve. The 10th Battalion, KOYLI war diary for the 1st July 1916 is very brief:

"The British offensive commenced, this battalion leading the 64th Brigade assault. They left the trenches at 7.30 a.m. and took Crucifix Trench that morning and held it till early the next day, when they were relieved by the 1st Lincolns. Casualties - Officers Killed: Capt. C.R. Heygate, Lt. J.W. Bamber, Lt. R.S.M. Beatson, 2nd Lt. J. Andrew, 2nd Lt. K.J.P. Asher, 2nd Lt. A.C. Cockroft, 2nd Lt. J.A.A. Fountain, 2nd Lt. M.E.J. Maude, 2nd Lt. L.F. Sharp, 2nd Lt. G.F.N. Wilkinson. Wounded 16 Other Ranks Killed 50, Wounded 292, Missing 135."

DEATH.

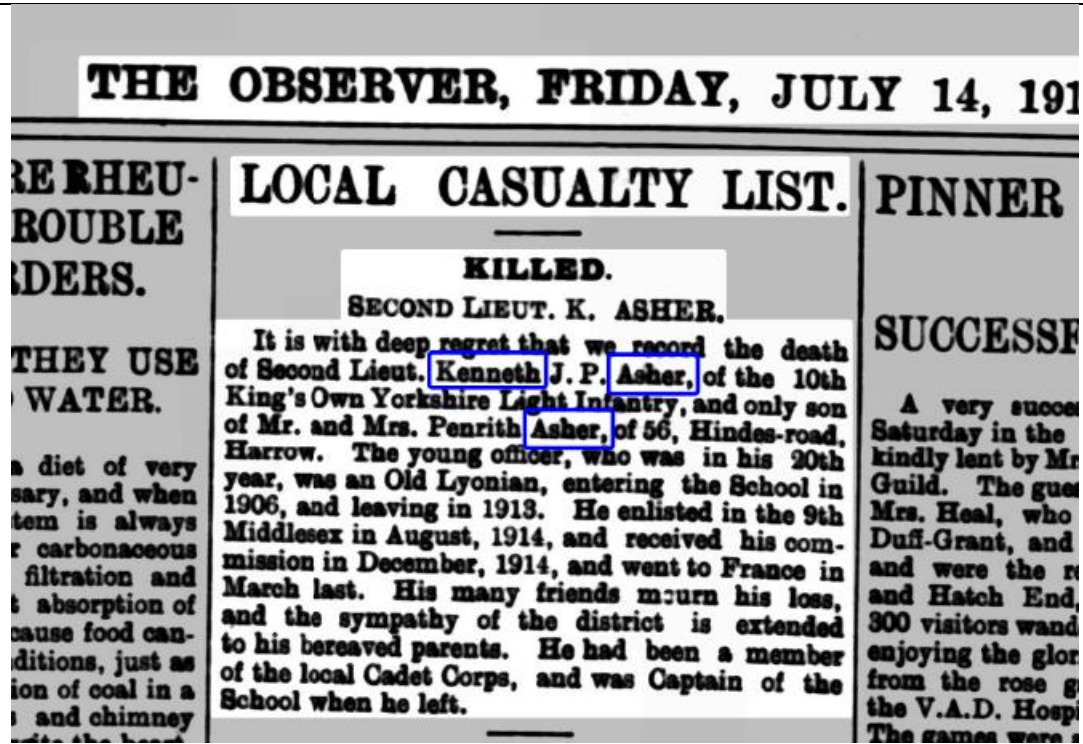
ASHER.—Killed in action in France, on July 2, Kenneth J. P. Asher, 2nd Lieut. 10th King's Own Yorkshire Light Infantry, only son of Mr. and Mrs. Penrith Asher, 56, Hindes-road, Harrow, in his 20th year.

BOUCKLEY —On July 3 at Sunnycote Marl.

DEATH.

ASHER.—Killed in action in France, on July 2, Kenneth J. P. Asher, 2nd Lieut. 10th King's Own Yorkshire Light Infantry, only son of Mr. and Mrs. Penrith Asher, 56, Hindes-road, Harrow, in his 20th year.

Image: also Harrow Observer, 14/7/1916



Harrow Observer, 14/7/1916

THE OBSERVER, FRIDAY, JULY 14,

LOCAL CASUALTY LIST.

KILLED.

SECOND LIEUT. K. ASHER.

It is with deep regret that we record the death of Second Lieut. Kenneth J. P. Asher, of the 10th King's Own Yorkshire Light Infantry, and only son of Mr. and Mrs. Penrith Asher, of 56, Hindes-road, Harrow. The young officer, who was in his 20th year, was an Old Lyonian, entering the School in 1906, and leaving in 1913. He enlisted in the 9th Middlesex in August, 1914, and received his commission in December, 1914, and went to France in March last. His many friends mourn his loss, and the sympathy of the district is extended to his bereaved parents. He had been a member of the local Cadet Corps, and was Captain of the School when he left.

Obituary 28/7/1916	
nd sti- ent the the ck, has med ed ole ion col. uld ex- her ted the eir pre- the off in ing was rry- rds zes. inta at was and ring uld ion- on with in post ark by ing ugh 300 De ing hed son, leat He died a hero's death fighting for his country's cause. SECOND LIEUT. K. ASHER. Second-Lieut. Kenneth J. P. Asher, of the 10th King's Own Yorkshire Light Infantry, whose death was recently recorded, was the only son of Mr. and Mrs. Penrith Asher, of 56, Hindes-road, Harrow. The young officer, who was in his 20th  year, was an Old Lyonian, entering the School in 1906, and leaving in 1913. He enlisted in the 9th Middlesex in August, 1914, and received his commission in December, 1914, and went to France in March last. He had been a member of the local Cadet Corps, and was Captain of the School when he left. PTE. FRANK WEBB. T Cor son an No Wol We had Jun wor Fra was of wel and re Hi offi tea the stor an Sch hin affe ren dev He inf the st ce ne we son J. dor dar wo is Mil pit ton	SECOND LIEUT. K. ASHER. Second-Lieut. Kenneth J. P. Asher, of the 10th King's Own Yorkshire Light Infantry, whose death was recently recorded, was the only son of Mr. and Mrs. Penrith Asher, of 56, Hindes-road, Harrow. The young officer, who was in his 20th year, was an Old Lyonian, entering the School in 1906, and leaving in 1913. He enlisted in the 9th Middlesex in August, 1914, and received his commission in December, 1914, and went to France in March last. He had been a member of the local Cadet Corps, and was Captain of the School when he left.

From the Centenary issue of the Lyonian, 2014 researched by students

Asher, K J P Kenneth John Penrith Asher was the son of George Willis Penrith Asher and Esther Fallon and was born in Algiers in 1887 and moved to England when he was young. His sisters were called Cecile and Geraldine; his great grandfather invented one of the first refrigerators. While he lived in Harrow, Kenneth and his family lived on 25 Hindes Road and while at John Lyon he became house captain; and at the age of 17 he left the School to join the Kings Own Yorkshire Light Infantry. He rose quickly to the rank of second lieutenant in the 10th battalion before being struck down in the first hour of the first day of the Somme offensive at the Battle of Loos. He is now buried at Norfolk Cemetery, NR Becaudel, Chateau Becourt, Northern France.	Asher, K JP Kenneth John Penrith Asher was the son of George Willis Penrith Asher and Esther Fallon and was born in Algiers in 1897 and moved to England when he was young. His sisters were called Cecile and Geraldine; his great grandfather invented one of the first refrigerators. While he lived in Harrow, Kenneth and his family lived on 25 Hindes Road and while at John Lyon he became house captain; and at the age of 17 he left the School to join the Kings Own Yorkshire Light Infantry. He rose quickly to the rank of second lieutenant in the 10th battalion before being struck down in the first hour of the first day of the Somme offensive at the Battle of Loos. He is now buried at Norfolk Cemetery, NR Becaudel, Chateau Becourt, Northern France.
2026 Notes and corrections: He was born in 1897 (not 1887) – his age when he died was 19 which means born 1897 The refrigerator info I didn't know about The 1/7/1916 is used here – there is disagreement about whether he died on 1 or 2/7/1916 but the war diary above indicates 1/7	

The following is info only – not necessary for his story:

Travel – research of passenger lists:

31/10/1913 The Arlanza bound for Buenos Aires, Argentina

Mr Asher, Agent, 41; Mrs Asher, 40; Miss Asher 14; Miss Asher, 12; and a maid all travelling first class to Argentina. So Kenneth doesn't seem to go with them.

I haven't located them or Kenneth in any other passenger lists.

Kenneth Asher Letters Home

22nd September 1915

Written on YMCA paper Paper

(folded with PASKOIT written on the front)

22nd Sept 1915

Dear Gerry

Thanks for your letter. I can't understand why your brooch arrived after Ma's because they were all three posted at the same time, but never mind, deeeear, they got there which was the main thing. I don't think I've got much to say, except that I am fed to the teeth with this battalion and want to get out to the Front quickly. I am writing this letter on some Y.M.C.A. paper that is in our hut. One of the chaps pinched it I suppose. Have you read the Budget? It's fearful, isn't it? I expect it will be some time before you see me, as I can't get sick leave and there is to be no ordinary leave for about a fortnight.

Well I think that's all I can muster to tell you for the present.

So Cheerioh, old dear

YAB

Kenneth

Undated letter

Young Officers Con

2nd Res. Inf Brigade

Penkridge Bank Camp

Stafford

Dear Gerry

Many happy returns of the day. I only wish I was there to wish it to you myself. I enclose a little "Sumpin" for you, as I have not been able to go anywhere to buy you anything myself.

Please thank Mother or Father for the shirt for me and tell Mother than I am not writing now as there is absolutely nothing to say. It has been rather rainy lately but yesterday and to-day have been fine and fearfully cold.

Don't forget do Mother's fizzly in her ear will you and tell Gran'ma not to worry if hers doesn't fizzle.

Well once more M.H.R. (many happy returns).

Love to you, Gerry dear, and everyone else.

From

Your loving brother

Kenneth

5th December ????

Y o c [Young Officers Con]

PBC [Penkridge Bank Camp]

Stafford

Dec 5th

Dear Cess

Here's many happy returns of to-morrow to you and a little sumpin to celebrate the occasion with.

Hope to be home for Xmas leave Either on the 22nd late or on the 23rd about mid-day till the 4th Jan I think.

Please thank Ma for her letter, and ask her to thank Gran'ma for the socks.

I don't know if you can read my writing or not but I have broken my middle finger or twisted it jolly badly. At any rate its all out of shape and looks very funny and is about as big as a sausage and is also very painful to use.

Please ask mother to excuse my writing for a day or two till it gets better.

Goodbye give my love to everyone and love to yourself

From

Y.E.B

Kenneth

1st January 1915

Thames Hotel Maidenhead letterhead

1st Jan 15

Dear Jerry

Just a line to thank you for your letter I can't write much as I have a lot of adding up to do.

That was rather cheek of Miss Rose I think.

I think you would enjoy yourself down here with the floods. Every time I go out I have to walk about 300 yards on narrow planks which are very wobbly. Now and then you hear a splash and see some unfortunate blighter wallowing in the water. I expect I shall fall in one of these nights as I am coming home drunk!!!!

I hope you can read this scrawl, but I am in a fearful hurry to do that work so

Goodbye with love

From

Kenneth

7th February 1915

Rugeley Camp B.O. Stafford

February 7, 15

Dear Girls

Thanks awfully for the toffee which I found awaiting me on my return and also for your letters.

Please thank Mother for her letter.

I didn't get back till about 6.30 this morning as I didn't get a taxi at Stafford and had to wait for a train. I didn't get any sleep but I'm not a bit tired.

That's all now

Goodbye

With love from

Y.E.A.B.

Kenneth

3rd April 1916

10 KOYLI [Kings Own Yorkshire Light Infantry]

21st Division

BEF

France

3 April 1916

My dear Cecile

Thanks for your welcome letter received this morning hoping it leaves you as it reaches me at present in the pink, as the men say. It is rather interesting work censoring letters. I have to do about 50 every day. Some of the men say some awfully funny things especially to the ones who write to their sweethearts. The weather out here is awfully warm like the middle of summer and I am now writing with my coat off and all the doors and windows open. If it goes on like this I shall want mother to send out some thinner underclothing.

We see lots of aeroplanes about every day. Some English, some French and one or two Huns. I saw the artillery firing at one yesterday: it looks jolly pretty, blue sky, silver aeroplane and lots of little puffs of white smoke looking like cotton wool floating in the air.

You remember Kennedy by name don't you? Well he is now a Captain and has got the Military Cross. I don't know what he did to get it; no one seems to know. No more now or else I shan't have anything to say to Jerry.

Love form

Y.E.M.L.A.H.T.B. Kenneth

26th April 1916

10 KOYLI [*Kings Own Yorkshire Light Infantry*]

BEF France

26th April 1916

Dear Gerry

Many thanks for your letter received a few days ago. I haven't much news to tell you but I'll try to write a bit. We seem to do nothing but push round France laden like mules. I have never been in one place more than 6 days. As usual I am writing on the banks of a stream, with aeroplanes, - French, German and British – buzzing about overhead. The last two days have been boiling hot and so I am sitting with my coat and hat off and thinking that it would be rather a good idea to dangle my feet in the water.

I expect you would rather like to be here as there are milkmaids and cowslips in profusion (ahem). Milkmaids are freecentral leguminosae aren't they? If they aren't they jolly well ought to be.

I heard the cuckoo yesterday for the first time this year.

I went to a gas demonstration yesterday (at least I had to go). I had to walk through a cloud of chlorine gas with a respirator on. They also fired off a lachrymatory bomb. That is one that makes you weep. I unknowingly walked into the gas. It smells very rich and fruity like strawberries and makes your eyes smart and tears come very freely.

No more to say now Gerry dear Except to ask you to tell Ma that I go the bags and buns alright.

Lots of love From

Y.E.L.L.O.W.B

Kenneth

Undated Letter

Dear Gerry

Thanks for your letter. Perhaps you have sent me out some measles germs in it and I shall get it once more.

We don't have to put any stamps on our letters out here so I write tons of them. Also field post cards. I wrote 16 p.c's yesterday to various people including Mother.

We are now in billets behind the firing line. I have got a bed, which is supposed to be a luxury, in a room all to myself. My old landlady is a very decent old bird and said she thought I was rather young to be out here fighting. She said I spoke French very well and when I told her I was born in Algiers she was awfully bucked. I had a long talk with her yesterday (Sunday) morning. I have my meals in another house where two of our officers sleep. It is really the vicarage (just behind the church) and as there is no parson here just now, it is let to people and we have got some of it. I isn't bad on the whole.

We are not a great distance from the trenches and we can hear the big guns going and sometimes machine guns and rifles. The big guns mostly fire just as I am going to bed and fairly shake the old house. Two shells dropped quite close to our place last night. I am getting used to the sound of artillery now, but I don't know what I shall be like when they begin to burst near me. I saw a captive observation balloon yesterday. They are funny shaped things. Something like this: - [sketch]

Please tell Mother not to bother to send out the Daily Graphic as we have papers sent out every day to the mess. There is a heavy strafe going on somewhere just now. We have been doing a good deal of marching lately and I am glad of a rest. I don't know when we are going to the trenches and neither does anyone else.

Goodbye

Love from your aff. bro. Kenneth

26th April 1916

10 KOYLI [Kings Own Yorkshire Light Infantry]

BEF

France [in deliberately shaky writing]

26 April 1916

Dear Cess

That's what I feel like; all wobbly like a wax candle is so hot.

I haven't much news. Did Mother get the photo I sent her. I enclose one for you and Gerry. Write back and let me know how you like it. I had a narrow escape the other night. I was behind the trenches with a working party when a bullet, zzzzz_____ ipp, went into the earth behind me. If I had been a yard further back I should have been on my way to Blighty now.

Coming back in the dark we halted for a rest I sat down and put my cap on what I thought was the ground but what turned out afterwards to be a sort of well. I turned my electric torch on and just managed to get it out. So I had to hand on the end of a rifle I was carrying for a lame man for the rest of the journey.

We aren't very comfortable here as we have two rooms for five of us and we have to sleep on a stone floor in a blanket. It's rather bony I can tell you. We have our meals in a smelly little sort of kitchen place. I shan't be sorry to get to the trenches and into a dug-out. We should be far more comfortable as there we sleep on wire netting nailed across poles which is top hole.

Please tell Father that the Captain of my Company was very gone on his cake.

No more now. Give my love to all

Lots of love to you, from

Y.O.I.C.K.B

Kenneth

24th May 1916

Letter to The Lyonian (School Magazine for John Lyon School, Harrow).

10 KOYLI [Kings Own Yorkshire Light Infantry]

BEF

France

24th May 1916

Dear Mr Swainson,

I will try to write you that letter I promised you. I expect you thought I had forgotten about it, but as a matter of fact, I have had nothing to write about.

Life out here I find very dull and boring, whether I am in the trenches or not. The bane of the Subaltern is work parties. They really are the most diabolical things one meets with. You may be sitting in your billet after dinner when a messenger bearing an envelope comes in. By the time your Captain has started to open the envelope you have already had grave forebodings, and so you discreetly retire into a dark corner of the room or grovel on the floor under the table after some imaginary article until he has picked upon some poor unfortunate. Then you emerge dishevelled but triumphant. If, however, there is no other Subaltern about, your name is called and you come reluctantly into the light, You are given instructions to proceed with 50 men (armed with picks and shovels) to a place which you have never heard of before. You start with the men and, ignoring any remarks about "Navvies' Battalions," you proceed to walk about France for the space of two or three hours. When you arrive at the spot – if you are lucky you should do – there will be someone there to tell you what to do. You start your men working, and, if energetic, work yourself. If you are not energetic, as is usually the case, you walk about and mutter unwritable things about the Kaiser and brood about the War.

On these working parties the men may have to do anything from unloading railway wagons to repairing trenches which have been damaged artillery fire.

Life in the trenches is usually very dull. When, however, it is not dull it is too exciting to be pleasant. You have most likely just managed to get to sleep in your dug-out, after having blocked up all the rat and mouse holes, so as to be able to get some peace, when a very tired and fed-up voice says "Twelve o'clock. Come along." And you are handed a Very pistol out of the darkness, and the Tired One disappears. You roll off your bed, if you have one, grab the Very pistol and commence your tour of the trenches armed to the teeth with this pistol and a revolver. I may say that the only use a revolver out here seems to be to shoot rats with. You stumble, if it is dry, or slide, if it is wet, round and succeed in nearly coming to an untimely end by being too absent-minded and taking no notice of the watchful sentry's challenge. When you begin to feel bored you amuse yourself by firing off the Very pistol; but even this palls after a time, as you still see the same old posts in front, which hold up the

barbed wire. Some wit or other on sentry will complain that he has been looking at the aforesaid adjective posts so long that they are forming fours. Now and then there is an artillery "strafe," which, as I said before, makes things too lively to be pleasant. While I was in the trenches last time I was in the hottest strafe this battalion has seen. It lasted an hour, and that was an hour's inferno. Not a second passed during the whole hour but there was not a whiz followed by a crash. The Germans' favourite shell is the whiz-bang, as it has been christened by our Tommies. It is really is a good name as it comes so quickly that it has exploded before you have time to duck. The Germans kept on sending over a lot of these with heavier shells now and then. One shell, a coal-box, dropped right on our roof of the dug out in the mouth of which I was crouching. Fortunately the dug-out was very strongly made indeed and I was only half buried in chalk. Several shells burst right in front of me, and I got the full benefit of the blast of the explosion right in my face. Of course they were some yards away or I should have been no more, but they burst close enough for me to feel the "breeze" and smell the powder. I was thankful when it was over, as it was the worst strafe I have seen. Directly it had finished I went round the trenches in search of souvenirs. I found a good many, most of which were the nose-caps of shells. I found one "dud" shell lying in the trench, but I thought it was too heavy and gave it to someone else who was more enthusiastic.

I have only been in one gas attack and that was lachrymatory gas, not asphyxiating, thank goodness. This lachrymatory gas has a rich fruity smell like strawberries and makes the eyes smart and water to such an extent that after a while it is impossible to see. It does not affect the lungs and its effect on the eyes wears off in about an hour. We are served out with, and always carry, a pair of goggles for protection against this gas.

I went to a "Flammewerfer" or Liquid Fire demonstration the other day. The apparatus had been captured from the Huns, and really is a most diabolical invention. It throws out an intensely hot flame about 20 feet long and also gives off clouds of thick black smoke. The term "liquid fire" is incorrect as it is not liquid and the flame is simply like a huge gas jet.

Kindest regards to all, from yours very sincerely,
KJP Asher